



SEVENTH HEAVEN: A view of Cumballa Hill overlooking the three residences

Versailles. At a price tag of an estimated \$1 billion (Rs 4,000 crore) it is the world's most opulent personal residence. Appropriately named after a mythical island in the Atlantic, it is complete with helipads, health clubs, gardens, a swimming pool and a movie theatre. It is the residence fit for someone *Forbes* ranks as the world's 14th richest person with a personal wealth of \$20 billion (Rs 80,000 crore).

He won't be the only billionaire on the block. Kumar Mangalam Birla (ranked 86 by *Forbes*, worth \$8 billion—Rs 32,000 crore) has moved into his newly renovated five-storey Indo-Gothic mansion on Carmichael Road. Across the road from Antilia, the Tata Housing Corporation has finished renovating The Cairn. There are no signs of Ratan Tata, ensconced in his apartment in Bakhtavar, Colaba, moving into the mansion (he recently ended speculation) and there is every possibility it may well be the future head honcho's official residence. London-based NRI Anil Aggarwal, worth \$3.8 billion (Rs 15,200 crore) and ranked 230 by *Forbes* constructed a two-storeyed residence five years ago and the Jains who own *The Times of India* group live here in the 10-storeyed Shikhar Kunj. Homes on a 1-km-long and 9-m wide road are just enough to let two cars drive past. Welcome to India's billionaire boulevard. It is an alignment of riches that is a novelty even for south

Mumbai, which boasts the largest concentration of corporate India's wealth. Here, real estate is amongst the most expensive in the world, nudging Rs 1 lakh a sq ft but it is the prospect of rubbing shoulders with corporate royalty that adds a premium to it. "Cumballa Hill is fast attaining the status of London's Hyde Park Lane," says Anuj Puri, chairman and country head Jones Lang LaSalle Meghraj. "All successful people want to live here and over the years I see it capturing a premium." It is already happening. Speculation is rife about the identity of the buyer who paid Rs 400 crore for a 1,000-sq m plot on the hill. These billionaire residences symbolise the vertical evolution of wealth in south Mumbai. Old money moved from Byculla to the colonial bungalows of Malabar Hill and Cumballa Hill in the late 19th century. JRD rented the Scottish-style bungalow The Cairn set in a one-acre plot, from his brother-in-law Sir Dinshaw Petit. It fell into disuse after JRD's death in 1993, almost living up to its Scottish name—a pile of sepulchral memorial stones—until it was purchased by the Tatas for Rs 50 crore nearly a decade ago. The original bungalow has been demolished and a new residence constructed in its place which retains the original character of the red-roofed bungalow. A seven-storey structure for senior group executives has been built on the property after demolishing staff

cottages.

Conservation architect Kirti Unwalla who identified the hill as a heritage precinct in a 2004 report for the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority, laments the changes taking place. From over a dozen bungalows with orchards and gardens a century ago, there is just one bungalow from the late 19th century which houses the Italian consulate, "all the footprints of the late 19th century are being erased". Antilia stands where the Petit bungalow once stood. The present Birla residence, for instance, was built after demolishing Anand Bhavan, a three-storey building where Jawaharlal Nehru's youngest sister Krishna Hutheesingh lived and where Rajiv Gandhi was born.

The Birlas purchased the one-acre plot nearly five years ago and two years



THE BIRLAS

This five-storey Indo-Gothic mansion on Carmichael Road was built after demolishing Anand

Bhavan, where Rajiv Gandhi was born. It has a rooftop swimming pool, a 20-seat theatre and a personal bunker dug into the hillside, to be used in case of a calamity.

